

and the working practices of an industry which in India is new and untested," says Ashray Gokul, Raptor's lead designer.

Sandeep and Jayanth started out with building a very small game concept to water their fantasies. As Sandeep puts it, the seed was a shared desire to create something that they cherished: "I was always fascinated with the depth of technicality that went into developing games. I had a background of building numerous applications, viruses (grins), 3D renderers—the ones you coded bit by bit (said with pride). It was natural to take it forward."

Vidyuth Srinivasan, business relations head, calls those at Raptor "children of art, music and technology". Ashray takes it further, "Sandeep, Vikram, Vidyuth and myself were part of a local rock band and we used to spend most of our chill-out sessions discussing games". He continues, "Initially, the project started out with only three full-timers while seven were part-time members. Gradually, as work piled on, the dynamics changed and Raptor had four full-time guys while the rest worked five to six hours a day".

Today, Raptor has 12 dedicated team members and two freelancers with the sole objective to develop Xtreme Forces, their maiden game.

Their designers work on nine machines powered by AMD processors and sundry 3D cards with monikers such as nVidia GeForce 6800 GT and ATi Radeon 8500.

Name Of The Game

Surprisingly, despite a huge software industry and an even bigger film industry, game development has hardly seen any growth in this country. A primary reason could be that building a game has long been associated with software than with entertainment.

As Vidyuth observes, "The (global gaming) industry is currently worth \$40 billion. The promotions for games worldwide are mind-boggling. An armed-forces title

There Is No Number One At Raptor

Sandeep and Jayanth say that without the entire team, Raptor would not have been possible. They give a big thumbs up to Vidyuth Srinivasan, Ashray Gokul, Akshay A V, Akshay B S, Joel Johnson, Keshav, Ravindra Kumar, Sudhir G N, Poorna Chandra Suraj, Vedavyas K P, Vijay R Sarthy, and Vikram Parthan. They say they are also indebted to the NVIDIA guys—Keita Iida, Darryl Still and Guy Grenier—in addition to Raptor Dad Narasimhan and Raptor Uncle Anand Mutalik.

recently saw soldiers staging a fake siege and then distributing free copies of the game to their 'hostages'. Talk about promotion! Entertainment drives the global economy today, and games are the biggest contributor."

Raptor's current project, Xtreme Forces has been in the making since October 2003. "I grew up reading about the Soviet Union and the cold war," says lead designer Ashray Gokul. "The elaborate and involved spy thrillers, (the works of) Boris Pasternak, Solzhenitsyn, the purges and the excesses of the Stalinist era... that's the stuff which fuelled my adolescent dreams. So it was natural for me to think of a game, based on events occurring after the fall of the Soviet Empire."

The highlight of Xtreme Forces has been the response and support the game has received from gamers, both in India and across the globe. The gaming community is tightly-knit—a ripple in the force is felt throughout the gaming world and a good creation is lauded almost as vehemently as a sub-par effort is mocked out of the collective.

Raptor Entertainment recently showcased a demo of Xtreme Forces at Game Developers Conference in San Jose, USA, in March this year. The Game Developers Conference, as the cliché goes, is the Mecca for the interactive art of game creation.

Far from being stoned or ridiculed, the response they received at GDC 2004 was excellent; these days many game publishers knock quite frequently on their doors. Raptor is wise beyond years though, as it patiently stalks the scene for a better deal in the offing.

The High Of Creating

Game development and production is a complex, lengthy process, which involves the integration of many specialised streams—from art, to history, to mathematics—a game leaves nothing untouched.

"Game development is all about being creative; you are constantly pushing the boundaries of communication and interaction.



From left: Keshav Damodaran, Level Designer; Vijay R Sarthy, Artist & Scripting; Akshay A V, Operations and Quality Assurance

Photographs: Srivatsa Shandilya

Buzzword of the MONTH

Podcasting

Podcasting is an exciting innovation. Thousands of people are doing it these days: audio blogs, radio shows, etc. are made available as MP3s; Podcasting entails using software—such as iPodder—to port

these MP3s from your computer to an iPod or any other MP3 audio device. It is thus a subscription service which comes from an original source—the 'PodCaster'—to an aggregator and then to you. How's that for democratic, ad-hoc radio?